are Kate cousins Milind and Swapnil. While Milind, a farmer and deputy sarpanch, is a staunch supporter of Sunetra, Swapnil, his next-door-neighbour and fellow farmer, is rooting for Sule. Explaining his choice, Milind says: "*Saheb* is in Delhi and *tai* is not in regular touch with us. Dada and *vahini* worked for us." However, for Swapnil, a self-confessed fan of "Saheb's *vichardhara* [ideology]," it was Pawar senior who gave Katewadi and Baramati their identity.

Another section of voters complains that the Pawar family feud is taking focus away from "real issues", such as the pollution of the Nira river—and its tributary Karha—in the area, water scarcity, the rising costs of education, lack of job opportunities and inflation. Industries are mostly concentrated around Baramati town, making it an island of prosperity, they add, and a proposed greenfield airport in Purandar (near Pune) is still awaited.

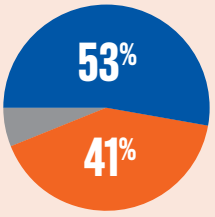
Sule launched her campaign on April 19 in the presence of her father and the extended Pawar family—including Ajit's younger brother Shrinivas a.k.a. Bapu—after breaking a coconut at the Hanuman temple in Kanheri, a village neighbouring Katewadi. A day later, Sunetra, too, visited the same temple in the company of her husband and supporters, before launching her campaign for Baramati. Launching election campaigns from this Hanuman temple has been a Pawar family tradition since Sharad Pawar, then 27, launched his career in electoral politics by successfully contesting from the Baramati assembly seat in 1967. Commenting on the voting patterns in Baramati in previous elections, political analyst Abhay Deshpande says, "So far, people here have been voting for *tai* in the Lok Sabha and *dada* in the assembly. This habit will now be broken. Will the voters think that Sharad Pawar is the past and Ajit Pawar the future? Or will they act against this notion?"

POCKET BOROUGH POLITICS

The past three general elections have seen Supriya Sule winning in Baramati

LOK SABHA 2019

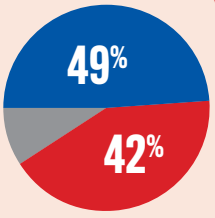
WINNER	RUNNER-UP
Supriya Sule (NCP)	Kanchan Rahul Kool (BJP)
686,714 votes	530,940 votes



Vote share

LOK SABHA 2014

WINNER	RUNNER-UP
Supriya Sule (NCP)	Mahadev Jagannath Jankar (RSP)
521,562 votes	451,843 votes



Others

Sympathy vs Vikas

According to the supporters of Pawar senior, Sule's biggest strength this election will be sympathy for her father, and the perception that the central agencies [a reference to probes into alleged irregularities by Opposition leaders being initiated and investigated by agencies like the ED] were used to split the party. On the other hand, those with Ajit say that his grassroots connect and his image as a '*vikaspurush*', or the man who developed Baramati and its institutions, will push his wife through.

Of the six assembly segments that are part of the Baramati Lok Sabha seat, the Opposition MVA holds just two—Purandar and Bhor, which have Congress MLAs. The other four are held by the ruling Mahayuti—Baramati and Indapur by the NCP and Khadakwasla and Daund by the BJP. Local workers of both camps are playing up the strengths of their own candidates, but there is some fear about the possible impact of the rift in the Pawar family and the NCP on the voters' psyche. According to Ajit loyalists, his image as the man responsible for Baramati's development and an aggressive go-getter, as well as members of the NCP's organisation and legislative wings walking out with him [a reference to leaders who sided with him in the rebellion against Sharad Pawar] would swing things their way. "The Lok Sabha election is focused on national issues," says Pradeep Garatkar, Pune district president, NCP. "Our opponents are trying to appeal to voters on emotional issues, but in the 10 years that Narendra Modi has been the prime minister, India has developed in material and social terms... they wrongly think that elections can be won on emotional planks," he added.

That sympathy for Pawar senior exists is something that even BJP leaders concede, but they doubt that Sule will be able to tap into it, considering her faction's alleged lack of organisational strength in some areas. Ajit has traditionally managed his uncle and cousin's Lok Sabha campaigns, which gives him the famed connect with the voters, say party workers. "In western Maharashtra, workers and voters go with individual leaders and this is why Sunetra's position is stronger as she enjoys the support of most local leaders. In contrast, Sule will find it tough to ensure booth-level management," claims